Who Changes Their Race, and Why?

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Abstract

While a growing body of work connects racial fluidity to inequality and politics, we know less about the social and demographic characteristics of individuals who change their race and how this process relates to other factors like religion. Leveraging a nationally representative, probability-based panel of over 16,000 U.S. adults from 2017 to 2024, I show that individuals who are younger, unmarried, lower SES, or living in the South and West are most likely to change their racial self-classification. However, being a political independent or moderate is, by far, the strongest predictor of instability in racial self-classifications. Employing a difference-in-differences design, I demonstrate that becoming Republican or college-educated predicts whitening, and this result is strongest among Latinos. Religion operates differently for Latinos and non-Latinos: Latinos who become Mormon shift toward nonwhite self-classifications, while non-Latinos who identify as Jewish shift toward white self-classifications. These findings update our understanding of racial fluidity and have implications for theories of ethnoracial boundaries and assimilation.

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Introduction

Once understood as an ascribed characteristic fixed at birth by hypodescent, racial identity is now recognized as flexible, the product of both ascription and self-identification claims (Brown and Jones 2015; Davenport 2016a). An increasing body of work finds support for considerable racial fluidity in the U.S., the notion that individuals' racial identities may vary over time, across contexts, and between racial categories (Telles and Paschel 2014). The growth of Latino and mixed race populations in the U.S. – fueled by immigration and rising intermarriages – is a key contributor to rising racial fluidity (Davenport 2020). In the 2020 Census, Latinos made up nearly 19 percent of the U.S. population, and non-Latinos selecting more than one racial option made up over 4 percent (Tian et al. 2025). Latinos – with ancestry in multiracial societies and historically straddling boundaries of whiteness (Fox and Guglielmo 2012) – blur prevailing administrative ethnoracial categories and complicate their mutual exclusivity.

While several studies have connected temporal fluidity in racial self-classifications to status and politics (Agadjanian and Lacy 2021; Antman and Duncan 2015; Egan 2020; Saperstein and Penner 2012), we know less about *who* exactly changes their race. What are the social and demographic characteristics of individuals who change their racial self-classifications, and how do racial self-classifications shift alongside other demographic changes? Data limitations – due to panel surveys with small sample sizes or only two or three waves – make it difficult to answer this question with sufficiently large demographic subcategories. Our understanding of how racial fluidity processes operate for highly mixed populations like Latinos draws from older panel studies based on singular youth cohorts, among whom racial identities may still be developing (Eschbach and Gómez 1998; Hitlin, Brown, and Elder 2006; Irizarry, Monk, and Cobb 2022).

In this paper, I extend this scholarship by investigating who changes their race and why, theorizing the social processes intertwined with racial fluidity beyond socioeconomic status and politics. Leveraging Pew Research's American Trends Panel (ATP) – a probability-based, nationally representative panel study of over 16,000 unique U.S. adults – I provide novel evidence on the extent of racial fluidity in the U.S. The panel includes repeated measurements of separate racial self-classifications, Latino origins, and other individual-level characteristics approximately one year apart from 2017 to 2024. I employ two-way fixed effects (TWFE) and the interactive fixed effects counterfactual estimator (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024) – robust to TWFE assumptions – to examine how short-term changes in racial self-classifications move alongside other demographic variables across up to eight waves.

Despite the increasing diversification of the U.S. and continued immigration and intermarriage, I uncover rates of racial fluidity similar to those found in past work. 6.5 percent of individuals change their racial self-classification from one wave to the next, and 13.1 percent change their self-classification at least once across the panel. Yet fluidity is disproportionately concentrated among Latinos. Breaking this down by separate Latino origin, I find that Latino self-classifiers represent 14 percent of the sample but 43 percent of race changes. Although whiteness is the most stable category, with over 97 percent of white self-classifiers continuing to identify as such in the next wave, Latinos make up over 42 percent of the less than 3 percent of changers.

I find that younger, lower SES, and unmarried individuals — along with political independents, moderates, and those residing in the South and West — are most likely to change their racial self-classifications. However, machine learning reveals that being an independent or moderate is by far the strongest predictor of race changes. At the individual level, I show that becoming more Republican or college-educated predicts movement to a white racial self-classification, and the results are strongest for Latinos. Religion has a distinct relationship for Latinos and non-Latinos, with identifying as Jewish whitening self-classifications among non-Latinos and becoming Mormon increasing the likelihood of non-white self-classifications among Latinos. Although the separate Latino self-classification is highly stable, identifying as Catholic is a significant predictor of changing one's origin to Latino.

This work makes several contributions. First, I present the most up-to-date portrait of racial fluidity among U.S. adults. White self-classification increases after individuals complete college and may represent a form of upward racial mobility for Latinos in particular. Second, my findings suggest that being a political independent or moderate carries racial meaning in an era in which party and race have become increasingly entangled (Westwood and Peterson 2020). Independents may exhibit higher rates of fluidity as they purposefully do not affiliate with party-race bundles. Finally, this work extends scholarship examining the link between race and religion (Davenport 2016b; Emerson, Korver-Glenn, and Wyndham 2015; d'Urso 2024). Among Latinos, joining the LDS Church – where boundaries of whiteness may be more narrowly drawn – actually increases nonwhite self-classification, in line with qualitative evidence on Latino LDS experiences (Romanello 2021).

Socioeconomic Status, Political Attitudes, and Racial Fluidity

Much of the research on racial fluidity in the Americas has focused on its relationship to socioeconomic status and inequality. In their seminal work, Saperstein and Penner (2010, 2012) show that individuals are more likely to be classified by others and self-classify as Black following unemployment or incarceration.[1] Davenport (2016b) demonstrates a nuanced relationship between socioeconomic status and racial self-classifications among biracial college students. While higher family income predicts whiter self-classifications, students with highly educated parents are *less* likely to do so and more likely to self-classify as multiracial, possibly because highly educated parents encourage awareness of their children's multiracial heritage.

In Latin America, where ethnoracial boundaries have historically been less rigid and

[1]For a critique of this work and their response, see Kramer, DeFina, and Hannon (2016) and Saperstein and Penner (2016).

more fluid than in the U.S. (Wimmer 2008), findings on the relationship between race and status are varied. Schwartzman (2007), for example, discerns that highly educated nonwhite parents in Brazil – particularly those with white spouses – are more likely to classify their children as white. Other work, however, argues that this relationship is context-dependent (Telles 2014; Telles and Flores 2013; Telles and Paschel 2014). Whereas "money whitens" in Brazil between the white and mixed race boundary, education may also increase Black self-classification, especially following the institution of affirmative action.[2] In other contexts, such as Colombia and the Dominican Republic, affluence does not predict racial self-classification, whereas mestizo or mixed race individuals have the highest average education levels in Colombia and Mexico. Still others argue that racial self-classification changes are next to impossible for many Afrodescendants (Golash-Boza 2010).

More recently, research in the U.S. has established a relationship between political behavior and racial fluidity. The two parties in the U.S. are strongly sorted along ethno-racial lines, with Republicans being overwhelmingly white and Democrats representing a multiracial coalition (Mason 2018; Westwood and Peterson 2020). In this vein, Agadjanian and Lacy (2021) find that individuals who switch to voting for Trump in 2016 are more likely to change their racial self-classification to white, mostly from initially Latino or mixed race. Similarly, Egan (2020) discerns that liberal Democrats are slightly more likely than conservative Republicans to self-classify as Latino in a later panel wave.

Other Influences: Gender, Place, and Religion

Beyond status and political attitudes, other factors like gender, age, and geography are intertwined with the construction of race. While women are not more likely to change their racial self-classification than men, the relationship between status and racial fluidity

[2] Telles (2014) and Monk (2016) also distinguish between "race" and "color," finding that interviewer-rated skin tone is a consistently strong predictor of status.

operates distinctly for men and women (Liebler et al. 2017; Penner and Saperstein 2013). Biracial women are more likely to self-classify as multiracial than biracial men, as ethnoracial stereotypes differ by gender (Davenport 2016b). Consistent with trends in ethnoracial diversification, younger people are more likely to change their racial self-classification, except among initial Latino and Native American self-classifiers (Liebler et al. 2017). This same work demonstrates that geography plays an important role. Individuals living in the West are more likely to change their racial self-classification on the Census – possibly due to the greater prevalence of intermarriages in this region – whereas biracial college students in the South are less likely to self-classify as multiracial (Liebler et al. 2017; Davenport 2016b).

Receiving comparatively less attention in the fluidity literature, religion has been closely tied with race since the colonial era (Emerson et al. 2015; Omi and Winant 1994). Whiteness and Protestantism were inextricably linked in the early U.S., and Supreme Court cases barring nonwhite people from citizenship sometimes drew upon Christian scripture (Bracey 2022). Over the past several decades, evangelicalism has become strongly linked to whiteness and conservative racial attitudes, despite notable ethnoracial diversity among evangelicals (Emerson 2001; Putnam, Campbell, and Romney Garrett 2012). At the same time, Black Protestant churches have historically served as sites of political mobilization and racial identity building (Pattillo-McCoy 1998; Brown and Brown 2003).

Islam, Judaism, and Mormonism – though smaller minority religions – are distinctly racialized. Historically excluded from whiteness (Goldstein 2008), Jewish people today overwhelmingly self-classify as white (Davenport 2016b). Muslims have become particularly racialized following 9/11, and conjoint experiments demonstrate that Muslims are more likely to be racially classified as nonwhite, controlling for phenotype (d'Urso 2024). Finally, Latinos represent one of the fastest growing demographics within the LDS (Mormon) Church, now representing 12 percent of Mormons (Smith et al. 2025). Qualitative evidence suggests that Latino Mormons experience racial othering and exclusion given the historical centrality of whiteness within the Mormon Church (Romanello 2021).

Latinos and Racial Fluidity

Past work has theorized fluidity as more common among (but not exclusive to) racially ambiguous and mixed individuals, and Latinos represent a key category in this regard (Hitlin et al. 2006; Eschbach and Gómez 1998; Irizarry et al. 2022). With ancestry in multiracial societies where race mixing was historically more common than in the U.S. (Davenport 2020; Hooker 2014; Telles 2014), Latinos' racial self-conceptions are particularly multidimensional and complex (Roth 2016; Telles 2018). In the U.S., Latinos have navigated historically blurry boundaries of whiteness. Following the Mexican American War, Latinos were granted citizenship and thus legally classified as white (Haney López 2006). Such legal whiteness was frequently used by Latino activists and elites to contest discrimination (Foley 1997; Gómez 2007). Socially, Latinos were sometimes considered white – dependent on skin color and SES – but in practice were often subject to racial exclusion and violence (Fox and Guglielmo 2012; Telles and Ortiz 2008). Today, panethnicity has become a predominant lens through which Latinos understand their race (Hitlin, Brown, and Elder 2007; Roth 2012; Mora 2014).

Reflecting this complexity, very high shares of Latinos change their racial self-classifications, depending on specific question wordings and options. For example, Saperstein and Penner (2016) report that 87 percent of Latinos in a multiyear panel have at least one discrepant racial classification by interviewers. Irizarry et al. (2022) find that nearly 60 percent of Latino youth change their racial self-classifications across seven years. Probing the processes related to this shift, they find that skin color and Caribbean ancestry are especially important predictors. Yet the Latino population in the U.S. has more than doubled since around the time that these panel studies of youth were conducted and diversified across national origins and generational status. How racial fluidity – and its relationship to politics, socioeconomic status, and religion – may differ among current Latino adults merits further attention.

Importantly, the racial self-classification questions in these surveys lack a Latino response option. It is likely that shifting to a combined race and Latino origin question would reduce fluidity rates among Latinos, given that most Latinos choose such an option alone when given the choice (Flores, Telles, and Ventura 2024). Yet, even among surveys with a Latino option, instability in the Hispanic or Latino category is around 20 percent (Agadjanian 2022; Eschbach and Gomez 1998). Further, while racial self-classifications on a separate race question may not represent Latinos' internal sense of identity (Dowling 2015), the processes connected to selecting into a category like whiteness are theoretically and empirically meaningful.

Theory and Expectations

As a social construct, race both shapes and is shaped by other categorical divisions like gender, socioeconomic status, religion, and place. Racial fluidity arises because the boundaries of racial categories are contextual and not fixed. As individuals experience changes in social categories like religion or class, they concurrently may shift or align their racial identities. These changes are concentrated among individuals belonging to ambiguous categories or with multiracial ancestry, since race for most white and Black Americans in particular remains highly stable and constrained by phenotype.

I focus here on racial self-classifications – the process of selecting one's race from a closed set of options – as a consequential process common in the U.S., though it may not accurately reflect one's internal sense of racial identity (Roth 2016).[3] From this perspective, changes in racial self-classifications may occur without changes to one's internal racial identity, depending on the specific question or options (Flores et al. 2024; Flores, Vignau

[3]For simplicity, I refer to "racial self-classifications" as "race" interchangeably in the text below, though race is a broader, multidimensional construct.

Loría, and Martínez Casas 2023). For example, an individual who understands their race primarily as Latino may at one point report their race as “White” and later shift to “Some other race”; a biracial individual with White and Asian parents may sometimes report their race as White, Asian, or both, depending on whether multiple responses are allowed. While these cases may not represent shifts in an individual’s internal identity, I argue that these changes nonetheless are purposeful choices to affiliate with a given racial category linked with other social processes. At the macro level, they evince the meanings behind instability in state-sanctioned racial categories.

Although the Census officially separates Latinos as an ethnicity, I treat Latino as an explicitly racial category in practice. Latinos are racialized distinctly and assumed to share certain physical features, yet Latinidad is not mutually exclusive from other categories like whiteness and Blackness (Brown and Jones 2015; Cobas, Duany, and Feagin 2009). When disaggregating racial fluidity by the separate Census Latino question, I recognize both measures as part of the same broader process of ethnoracialization (Wimmer 2008; Omi and Winant 1994). I refer to racial categories rather than groups throughout to acknowledge their contingent, often state-imposed nature (Brubaker 2002).

I detail the following broad expectations. First, in addition to being most common among Latinos and multiracial individuals, I expect that younger, unmarried, lower SES individuals and those residing in the West will be more likely to change their racial self-classifications. This follows from the increased intermarriages and diversification – most likely concentrated among youth and in the West – and the greater stability of identity among higher status individuals. Second, consistent with prior work, individual-level changes in socioeconomic status, party ID, and ideology should be associated with race changes such that higher SES and rightward shifts in party ID and ideology will predict moving toward a white self-classification. However, I hypothesize that this relationship will be strongest among Latinos, for whom whiteness has been historically tied to upward mobility and conservative politics.

Finally, I anticipate that racial self-classifications will move alongside religious and geographic changes. Individuals who move to the West should be less likely to self-classify as white, whereas individuals who become Evangelical or Mormon should be more likely to self-classify as white. Taking into account the cultural significance of Catholicism within Latinidad, I expect movement to Catholicism to predict changes into a Latino origin self-classification, while becoming Muslim should correspond with nonwhite self-classifications. Despite being historically racialized as nonwhite, Jewish individuals overwhelmingly self-classify as white. I thus anticipate that Jewish identity should correspond with whiter self-classifications, though this may not necessarily reflect lived experiences of race.

Data and Methods

Data

I draw upon Pew Research Center's American Trends Panel (ATP) to assess racial fluidity. Since 2014, the ATP is one of the largest ongoing nationally representative panel surveys in the U.S., with around 10,000 panelists selected through probability sampling per wave and surveyed in both English and Spanish. I analyze eight waves roughly one year apart from 2017 to 2024,[4] resulting in a panel of N=16,469 unique individuals present for at least 2 waves and 78,268 individual-panel observations; individuals are present for a median number of four waves. The large sample size enables analysis of subcategories typically underrepresented in smaller panel studies. As most respondents are present for more than two waves, it also enables the analysis of within-respondent changes beyond two points in time.

The primary dependent variable is racial self-classification, which asks, "What is your

[4] This is because demographic questions are not re-queried on each wave. From personal communication with Pew, these waves are the ones in which demographics were asked anew of respondents and are publicly available.

race or origin?" Options were "White," "Black or African American," "Asian or Asian American," "Mixed Race," "Some other race," and Don't Know / Refused. Like the Census, the Pew question separates race and Latino origin but differs in its inclusion of a mixed race option, its lack of a Native American option, and in only allowing one response (rather than multiple). This question is consistent across waves. For simplicity, and given the salience of the white-nonwhite boundary, I construct a binary variable for whether a respondent self-classified as white or nonwhite at a given point in time. The separate Hispanic or Latino origin question read, "Are you of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin, such as Mexican, Puerto Rican or Cuban?" with options "Yes," "No," and Don't know / Refused.[5] [6]

Appendix Table A1 presents the distribution of key variables at the time of entry into the panel compared to national benchmarks from the American Community Survey and the 2020 ANES for party ID and ideology. In line with the probability sampling strategy, the ATP is largely representative across key variables, with a few exceptions. The panel both underrepresents individuals ages 18-29 and overrepresents those over age 65. However, given the literature's focus on youth panel studies, this is itself a feature of the data, enabling us to make claims about racial fluidity among the older adult population. Men and noncitizens are slightly underrepresented. The survey was only available in English and Spanish, whereas 9 percent of adults speak another language at home. Likely related to the mode of interview (either online or by telephone), college-educated respondents are overrepresented.

Methods

I characterize racial fluidity in one of two complementary ways. First, I examine changes from one wave to the next as a function of respondents' demographics in the prior wave.

[5] In supplemental analyses, I examine shifts into and out of the Black category – though it represents a much lower share of race changes – and the Latino category from the separate origin question.

[6] I choose to keep "Don't know / Refused" as a valid response rather than drop it as missingness, as Pew codes it separately from simple missingness and many respondents in this category later move to another category.

This approach allows us to assess short-term changes and account for changing demographics, though it is not at the individual level since not all respondents are present in all waves. Second, I assess whether individuals change their race at least once over the panel, using their demographics measured at their first wave of participation. This approach captures within-person instability over a longer time horizon, but it holds demographics fixed at baseline.

- **(Racial) Fluidity Measure 1**: The share of responses at time *t* that have a different response at time *t+1*.
- **Measure 2**: The share of respondents changing their race *at least once* across the entire panel, using demographics at the first wave they are recruited.

In the first part of the analysis, I examine descriptive patterns in racial fluidity using these two primary measures and compare racial fluidity to instability in other demographic variables. I then use random forests (Montgomery and Olivella 2018) to assess the most predictive variables of changing one's racial self-classification to understand who is most likely to change their race. Key predictors include age, region, sex, citizenship, language of the survey, marital status, religion, an evangelical binary, education, household income, party ID, and ideology. Note that all questions remained constant across the panel *except* for sex, which shifted to a *gender* question in 2020.[7]

In the second part, I examine how individual-level changes in demographics predict moving into or out of a white or nonwhite self-classification using the two-way fixed effects estimator (TWFE), a generalized form of the difference-in-differences estimator:

$$\text{White}_{it} = \beta_1 \cdot \text{X}_{1it} + \beta_2 \cdot \text{X}_{2it} + ... + \beta_n \cdot \text{X}_{nit} + \alpha_t + \theta_i + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

[7]From 2017 to 2019, the *sex* question asked: "Are you male or female?" with two options, male and female. From 2020 onward, the *gender* question asked, "Do you describe yourself as a man, a woman or in some other way?" with three options, "A man," "A woman," and "In some other way." For consistency, I refer to this variable as *sex* throughout.

In the above equation, White_{it} represents a binary for whether respondent i self-classified as white at period t. X_{1it} to X_{nit} represent the values for primary "individually varying" predictors, including region, marital status, religion, the evangelical binary, education, household income, party ID, and ideology. Importantly, I exclude age (since it changes only as respondents age), sex (since very few people change their sex, and options are limited to male and female before 2020), citizenship (also a very low frequency change), and language of the survey (constant for all respondents). Finally, α_t represents time (wave) fixed effects, and θ_i represents respondent fixed effects.

Leveraging within-individual variation, this approach examines how changes in demographics like income or party ID move alongside changes in racial self-classifications. This accounts for time-invariant differences across individuals (e.g., skin color) as well as common time shocks. However, this approach does not account for unobserved, time-varying confounders, which limit causal identification. Additionally, the TWFE estimator relies on strong functional form assumptions and may produce biased estimates in the case of staggered treatment adoption or multiple periods, as is the case with this data (Imai and Kim 2021). Accordingly, I employ the interactive fixed effects counterfactual (IFEct) estimator as a robustness check (Liu et al. 2024). The IFEct estimator relaxes the functional form and homogeneous treatment-effect assumptions of TWFE. While the IFEct estimator only allows binary treatments, I replicate TWFE analyses with dynamic treatment effects for binary indicators for completing college, self-classifying as Latino, and becoming a Democrat / Republican.

Results

How many people change their race?

I begin by examining the extent of race changes compared to other social characteristics. Table 1 presents rates of change across race and other key variables. The first column corresponds to the first measure of fluidity discussed above: the share of race (or other) responses that are different between time *t* and time *t+1*, approximately one year later. The second column displays the second measure: the share of individuals who change their race (or other characteristics) at least once across the entire panel.

Variable	**% Change between waves**	**% At Least 1 Change**
Race	6.5	13.1
Latino Origin	1.8	4.2
Age	6.5	22.9
Region	1.3	4.1
Sex	1.3	3.1
Citizenship	0.8	1.9
Marital Status	3.6	10.9
Religion	15.2	30.1
Evangelical	7.6	16.0
Education	9.8	21.3
Income	46.0	74.6
Party ID	6.8	15.9
Ideology	19.5	38.9

Table 1: Changes across key variables. This table presents instability across key variables. The first column displays changes from one wave to the next, e.g., the share of race responses at time *t+1* that were different from those at time *t*. This is not at the individual level, since the panel is unbalanced. The second column displays the share of unique individuals who have one or more changes in a given variable across the full panel.

Table 1 reveals that race changes are relatively uncommon but nontrivial. Around 6.5 percent of respondents change their racial self-classification between waves, while over 13 percent change their self-classification at least once across the full panel. Instability in racial self-classifications is comparable to that of party ID (with 6.8 percent changing between Democrat, Republican, and Independent over a year). Race changes are much less frequent than changes in religion, income, and ideology but much more common than changes in region, sex, citizenship, and marital status. Income is by far the most unstable variable, in part due to its granularity – featuring 9 categories – but also likely because household income varies year-to-year. Sex changes become more frequent after 2020, when the panel moved toward a gender question with a third option. Low rates of regional change are consistent with American Community Survey data on moves, since only around 2 percent of Americans move across states from year-to-year.

Interestingly, the Latino origin question is much more stable than the race question, with less than 2 percent of respondents changing from one year to the next and only around 4 percent across the full panel. Overall, the Pew data evinces rates of fluidity similar to those found in past work (Agadjanian 2022; Liebler et al. 2017; Saperstein and Penner 2012), though with greater stability in the separate Latino question. This is somewhat surprising given the recent time frame of the data and suggests that increased diversification and intermarriages may not necessarily increase fluidity.

Who changes their race?

Next, I turn to understanding which individuals are most likely to change their race. First, in Table 2, I examine rates of racial fluidity by distinct categories. As before, the first column presents the share of respondents who self-classified with a given category at time *t* and switched to a different category at time *t+1*. The second column presents the share of these switchers who self-classified as Latino in the separate question at time *t*. Finally, the third column presents the share of individuals who *first* self-classified as White, Black, etc. and changed their race at least once. I repeat this same process for the Latino origin question.

Racial fluidity rates vary dramatically by category, with the White and non-Latino categories remaining strongly stable and the Black, Asian, and Latino categories following. The ambiguous or mixed race categories feature large shares of fluidity. For example, looking at column 3, a majority of initial Mixed race, Some other race, and Don't know self-classifiers will change their race at least once across the panel. The most striking finding, however, is the overrepresentation of Latino self-classifiers within each of these strata. For example, while Latinos make up 13.9 percent of panelists, they represent over 40 percent of the 2.6 percent of white self-classifiers who change their race from one wave to the next. Latino self-classifiers are a disproportionate share of all subsequent category

Category	% Change between waves	% Latino	% At Least 1 Change
Race			
White	2.6	42.1	7.0
Black	6.6	17.6	12.9
Asian	5.7	34.4	9.0
Mixed race	37.3	36.1	50.9
Some other race	36.2	78.8	62.6
Don't know / refused	58.8	32.1	85.2
Latino Origin			
Latino	5.2		9.4
Not Latino	1.0		2.8

Table 2: Racial fluidity rates by racial category. This table presents instability in separate race and Latino origin responses by category. Similar to Table 1, the first column presents the share of White, Black, etc. self-classifiers at time *t* who had a different race response at time *t+1*. The second column calculates the share of changers within each category who were Latino at time *t*. The third column presents the share of individuals who change their self-classification at least once across the panel by their baseline self-classification at the time in which they joined the panel. This process is repeated below for the separate Latino origin question. The second column is blank here because Latinos, by construction, make up 0 and 100 percent of such individuals at time *t*.

race-changers and make up nearly 80 percent of Some other race changers (though they represent a similar share of Some other race self-classifiers at baseline). These findings reveal the extent to which racial fluidity is a Latino phenomenon and the extremely high stability of the White category once accounting for Latinos.

Figure 1 displays the destination categories of changers using the first column (Measure 1). That is, of the 2.6 percent of white self-classifiers or 6.6 percent of Black self-classifiers in time *t* who switch, which categories do they move to in the next period? In general, movement is greatest between White, Mixed, and Some other race (SOR) categories, though some specific patterns emerge. For example, among Black and Asian changers, a plurality (over 40%) move to the Mixed category. This could potentially represent Black-White and Asian-White biracial individuals navigating historical hypodescent rules (Davenport 2016b; Ho et al. 2011). By contrast, a majority of Mixed race, SOR, and "Don't know" changers move to the white category, and among white changers, very few move to the Black and Asian categories.

Moving on to other social characteristics, Table 3 presents a portrait of racial fluidity

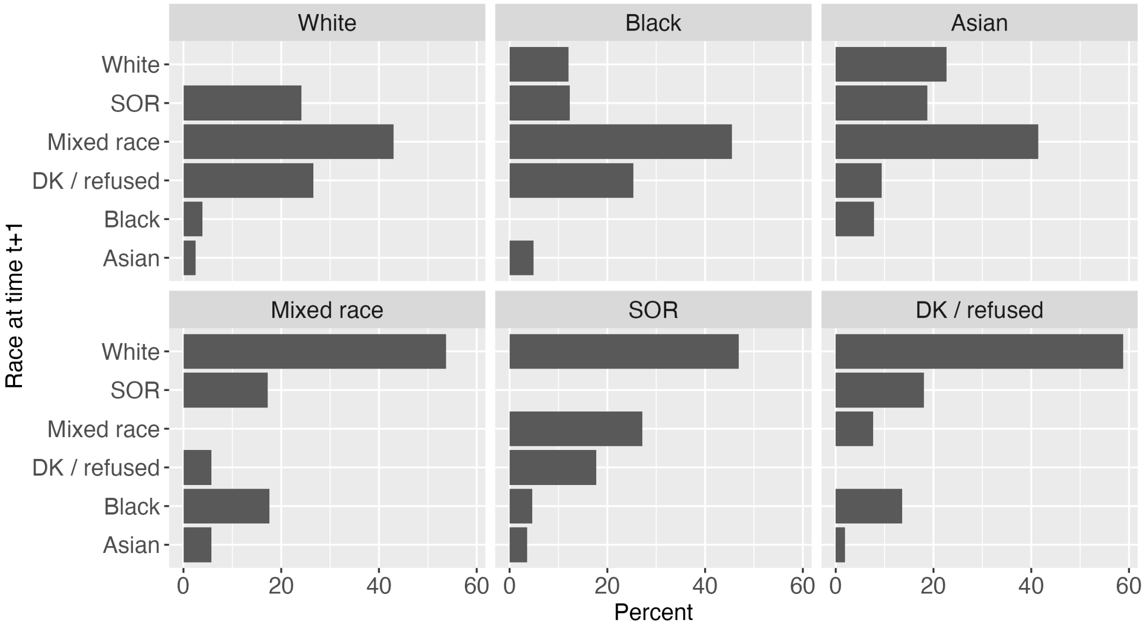

Figure 1: Distribution of race at next period for changers. This figure presents which categories respondents who change their race move to. Each panel displays – for respondents who identified with a given category (e.g., Asian) at time *t and* changed their race – the distribution of race responses at time *t+1*. By design, the same category within each panel is zero. The x-axis displays percents, which sum to 100.

across major social categories. Several patterns emerge consistent with past work. Younger, unmarried, and lower SES individuals are more likely to change their race. In addition to the West, the South shows higher rates of racial fluidity, which is surprising given the history of the one-drop rule. Differences by sex and whether one identifies as Evangelical are small. Noncitizens and those who took the survey in Spanish – categories in which Latinos make up 62 and 98 percent, respectively – are much more likely to change their race. Interesting findings also emerge for party ID and religion. Muslims are the most likely to change their race, while Jewish people are the least. Democrats and Republicans are about as likely to change their race, but independents (as well as political moderates, from the separate ideology question not displayed in Table 3) are substantially more likely to do so. This finding aligns with work on the increasingly strong link between party ID and race (Mason 2018; Westwood and Peterson 2020). If partisanship is increasingly racialized,

Variable	% Change between waves	% At Least 1 Change
Age		
18–29	9.9	17.3
30–49	7.6	14.8
50–64	6.2	12.6
65+	4.4	8.9
Region		
Midwest	4.3	8.7
Northeast	5.8	11.6
South	7.1	14.2
West	8.2	16.8
Sex		
Female	6.3	12.6
Male	6.6	13.7
Other	17.6	34.3
Citizenship		
Citizen	6.3	12.5
Noncitizen	17.0	31.4
Language		
English	6.1	12.2
Spanish	21.6	41.3
Marital Status		
Married	5.6	11.7
Not married	7.7	14.8
Religion		
Protestant	5.8	11.6
Catholic	8.0	16.6
Jewish	3.3	7.1
Muslim	10.3	11.2
Mormon	6.2	10.7
Agnostic / atheist	4.2	8.5
Other / nothing	7.8	16.1
Evangelical		
Evangelical	7.2	14.6
Not Evangelical	6.3	12.6
Education		
HS or less	8.8	17.2
Some college	7.9	15.4
College+	4.9	10.3
Income		
1st Quartile	9.3	17.8
2nd	7.0	14.6
3rd	5.0	12.0
4th	3.9	7.9
Party ID		
Democrat	6.4	12.6
Independent	16.4	28.2
Republican	6.0	12.5

Table 3: Racial fluidity rates by demographic categories. This table presents racial fluidity rates by different demographic categories. As before, the first column presents the share of a given category (e.g., those age 18-29) at time *t* who change their race between time *t* and *t+1*. The right column displays, for example, the share of all individuals ages 18-29 at entry to the panel who change their race at least once.

then it follows that individuals with unstable racial identities are most likely to be political independents.

The previous analysis clarifies the prevalence of racial fluidity across major social categories, but many of these characteristics – for example, income and marital status – are correlated. To account for these correlations, I next turn to random forests to flexibly determine the strongest predictors of racial fluidity without functional form assumptions. Figure 2 presents variable importance measures (VIMs) from random forests regressing the two measures of racial fluidity (changes from one wave to another and changes across all waves) on demographic variables. The VIMs compute the decrease in mean-squared error (MSE) at each predictor's true value versus at permuted values (Wei, Lu, and Song 2015), thus capturing which predictors explain the most variation in the outcome.

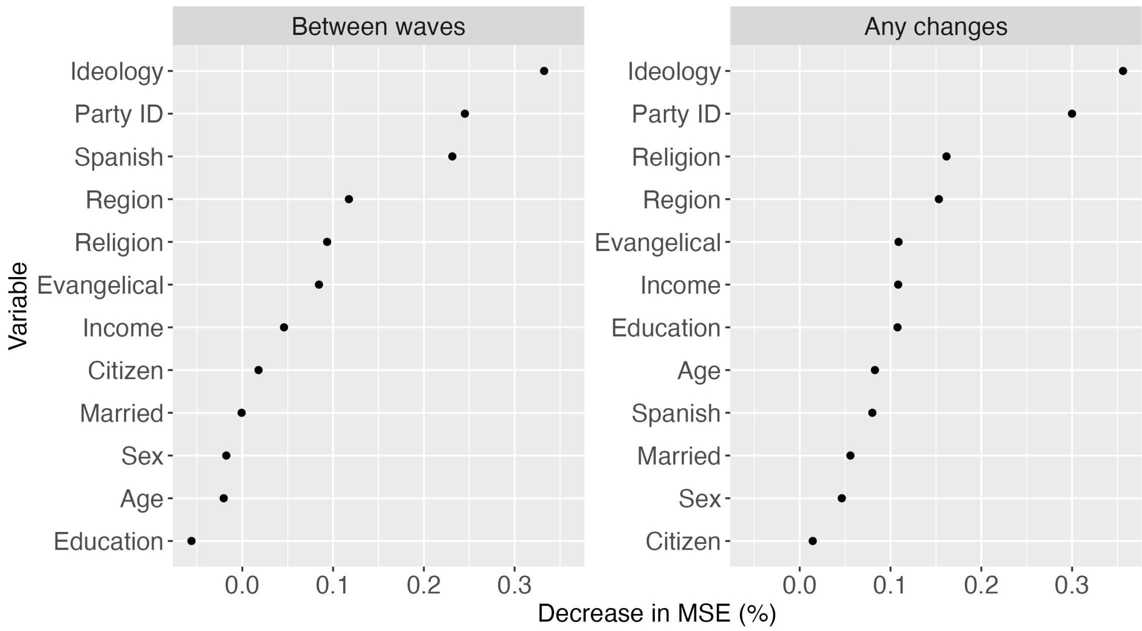

Figure 2: Most predictive variables of racial fluidity from random forests. This figure plots permutation variable importance measures (VIMs) from random forests regressing the two measures of racial fluidity on key variables. The x-axis plots the reduction in mean-squared error in descending order. The left panel examines fluidity between two waves (measure 1), while the right panel examines whether a respondent ever changes their race by demographics at the first period (measure 2).

Figure 2 plots the decrease in mean-squared error from highest to lowest, and ideology and party ID emerge as the two strongest predictors of racial fluidity. As noted before, political independents and moderates are the most likely to change their race, and this explains the most variation in racial fluidity among any of the variables. Next, both region and religion are moderate predictors, whereas whether the survey was taken in Spanish is a stronger predictor only for the between waves measure. Interestingly, whether a respondent is Evangelical also emerges as a moderate predictor of both measures, although partial dependence plots reveal Evangelicals are only a few percentage points more likely to change their race.

By contrast, sex, age, and education for the first measure explain among the least variation. The VIMs being below zero for sex, age, and education for this measure means that shuffling these variables at random actually enhances the predictive success rate of the model, indicating they are not helpful for prediction after accounting for other factors. For the measure of any changes across the panel, marital status, sex, and citizenship are the least predictive variables. This suggests that some variables – such as marital status or age – are not helpful in predicting racial self-classification changes once accounting for correlations. Overall, these findings demonstrate that party ID, ideology, religion, and region explain the most variation in fluidity net of other social characteristics.

Do race changes align with other demographic shifts within individuals?

Having established the extent and demographic sources of racial fluidity, I turn to leveraging within-individual variation to understand whether changes in racial self-classifications move concurrently with other demographic changes. Table 4 plots coefficients from OLS models regressing a binary variable for whether a respondent self-classified as white on key variables, with fixed effects for individuals and waves. The first column draws from the full sample. The second and third models examine respondents who self-classified as Latino at any point or who never classified as Latino, given much higher rates of fluidity among

Latinos. Recall that with the exception of marital status and region, these variables exhibited relatively high rates of instability, enabling a within-person analysis. Sex, citizenship, and language of survey are excluded because they rarely (or never, in the case of language) change within individuals.

Looking at the full sample, party ID, education, and being Latino are significantly related to movement into or out of the white category. The coefficient on education indicates that moving from a high school to a college education is associated with a 2 percentage point increase in the probability of self-classifying as white. The magnitude of the party ID coefficient is similar, signifying a 2 percentage point increase in the likelihood of self-classifying as white moving from strong Democrat to strong Republican. The coefficient on Latino suggests that when individuals move toward a Latino self-classification on the separate origin question, they are 7 percentage points more likely to move away from the white category. Interestingly, neither income nor any other variable besides party ID, education, and being Latino significantly predicts white self-classification. Coefficients for income and being Evangelical are close to zero, contrary to expectations. This latter finding may reflect the increased diversity of Evangelicals and distinct Black and white Evangelical traditions.

The second and third columns reveal that the full results conceal important variation among Latinos and non-Latinos. As hypothesized, the relationships between party ID, education, and white self-classification are stronger among Latinos, though the coefficient is not statistically significant for education. With respect to religion, Latinos who become Mormon are significantly *less* likely to self-classify as white by over 10 percentage points, possibly because the boundaries of whiteness are more narrowly drawn in this context. Non-Latinos who identify as Jewish, on the other hand, are more likely to move into the white category. The data cannot speak to whether shifting to a Jewish religious classification signifies conversion – either independently or through marriage – but, rather, may encompass individuals with Jewish ancestry or ties who selectively report membership.

	White Self-Classification		
	Full Sample	Latino	Non-Latino
Income	0.00	0.02	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Education: Some college	0.01	0.01	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.00)
College+	0.02*	0.03	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)
Party ID	0.02*	0.04*	0.01*
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Ideology	0.01	0.02	0.01*
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Latino	-0.07*		
	(0.02)		
Religion: Agnostic/Atheist	0.00	0.03	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Catholic	0.01	0.01	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)
Jewish	0.03	-0.02	0.05*
	(0.02)	(0.06)	(0.02)
Mormon	-0.04	-0.11*	0.00
	(0.02)	(0.05)	(0.01)
Muslim	-0.03	-0.14	0.01
	(0.03)	(0.08)	(0.04)
Nothing	0.01	0.01	0.01
	(0.00)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Other	-0.01	-0.08*	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.03)	(0.01)
Married	0.00	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Evangelical	0.00	0.01	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.01)	(0.00)
Region: Midwest	0.00	0.00	-0.01
	(0.01)	(0.09)	(0.01)
South	0.01	0.06	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.07)	(0.01)
West	0.01	0.11	-0.01
	(0.01)	(0.07)	(0.01)
Respondent FE	✓	✓	✓
Wave FE	✓	✓	✓
Observations	72,659	10,625	62,034
R^2	0.908	0.764	0.942
Within R^2	0.003	0.005	0.001

Clustered (Respondent) standard errors in parentheses.
$^*p < 0.05$

Table 4: Two-way fixed effects models predicting changes in white self-classification. This table presents coefficients from two-way fixed effects OLS models with white self-classification as a binary DV. The models assess how within-individual changes predict movement into or out of the white category. The first model draws upon the full sample, the second subsets to respondents who self-classified as Latino at least once in the separate Latino origin question, and the third subsets to respondents who were never Latino in the separate origin question. The baseline levels for the categorical variables are high school or less (for education), Protestant (for religion), and Northeast (for region). The remaining variables are numeric (income, party ID, ideology) or binary (Latino, married, Evangelical).

Because movement in and out of whiteness represents only one type of race change, in Appendix Table A2, I examine movement around the Black and Latino (from the separate origin question) categories. These changes are less common than those around the white category, so estimates are less precise. Consistent with findings for whiteness, individuals who complete college are less likely to self-classify as Black or Latino, but findings are not statistically significant. The only statistically significant finding is that becoming Catholic predicts shifts into Latino self-classification, which aligns with the cultural significance of Catholicism within Latinidad. Overall, these findings evince strong support for the relationship between party ID changes and racial fluidity, some support for socioeconomic status changes and whitening racial self-classifications, and the underexplored role of religion changes.

Additional analyses: Measurement error and IFEct estimator

I conduct two additional analyses to ensure the results are not driven by measurement error or by the stringent assumptions of TWFE. First, I drop all respondents who have either more than one citizenship or age change as likely misreporting and rerun the analyses in Table A3. Losing citizenship is exceedingly rare, so respondents with more than one citizenship change are likely to have misreported at one point. Recall that age is measured with four categories (age ranges 18-29, 30-49, 50-64, 65+) such that more than one age change across the 8-year panel is impossible. This drops 214 individuals (1.3 percent of the panel). Results remain substantively the same, though the coefficient on education is no longer statistically significant.

Second, I turn to the interactive fixed effects counterfactual estimator as a stronger alternative to TWFE. The IFEct estimator only assesses binary treatments, so I create binary variables for completing college, becoming a Democrat, and becoming a Republican as "treatments." I replicate TWFE results with these variables – as well as the Latino binary – in Figure 3 with a dynamic treatment effects plot. Reassuringly, there do not appear to be clear pretrends except for becoming Republican, where changers are somewhat more likely to self-classify as white in the pre-period, though effects are imprecise and bootstrapped confidence intervals are wide. Treating this variable with caution, results substantively replicate TWFE findings. Individuals who complete college are somewhat more likely to shift into a white self-classification two waves later, and individuals who self-classify as Latino are less likely to self-classify as white in the next two waves. Similar patterns hold for Republican and Democrat changers, though effects are smaller and quite imprecise. In Appendix Figure A1, I demonstrate that findings on whitening alongside Jewish identification for non-Latinos and shifts to nonwhite classification among Latinos who become Mormon also hold.

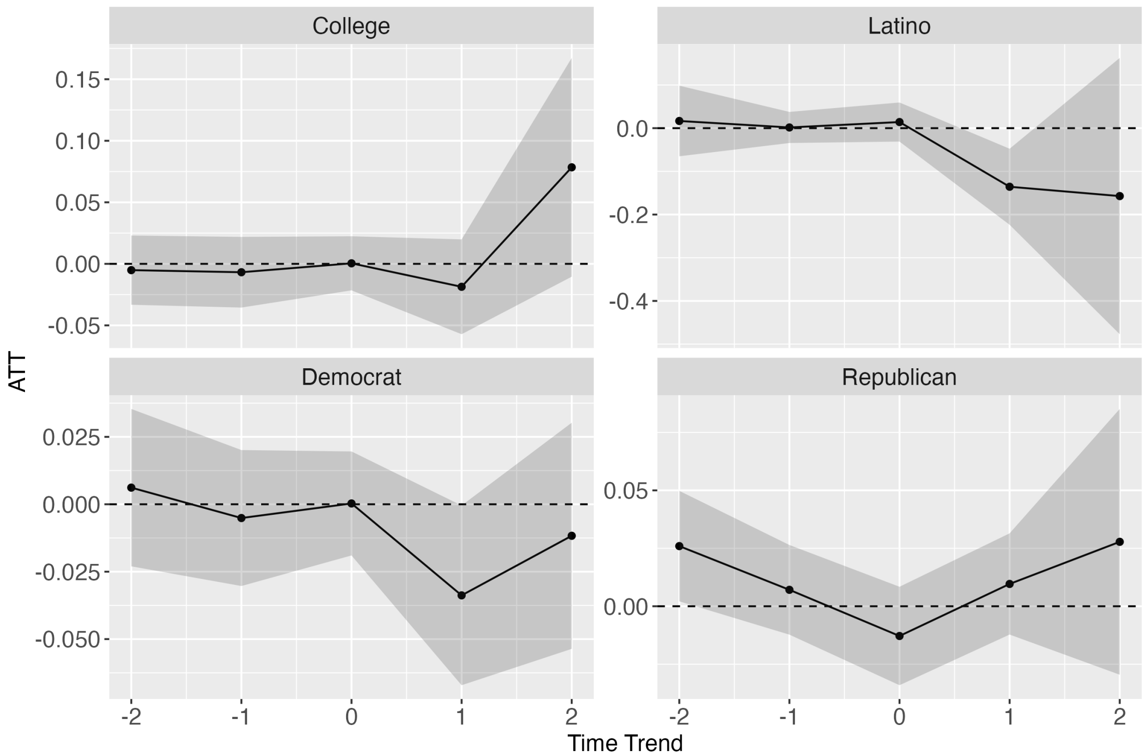

Figure 3: Effect of college, PID, and Latino self-classification on white self-classification. This figure presents time trends for the average treatment effect on the treated for white self-classification using the interactive fixed effects counterfactual (IFEct) estimator. Each panel represents a binary "treatment" variable: Completing college, self-classifying as Latino, identifying as a Democrat, and identifying as a Republican at time t = 0. 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals are included.

Discussion and Conclusion

Acknowledging the constructed and contextual nature of race, a growing body of work in the social sciences has sought to understand racial fluidity – the notion that race is not fixed and may vary over time within individuals. In this paper, I build upon and extend this scholarship by investigating who exactly changes their race and why. I theorize the social processes intertwined with the construction of race beyond status and politics, and I draw upon comparative work in Latin America to explore how these processes may differ for Latinos, who make up nearly one in five individuals in the U.S. and have historically complicated ethnoracial categorization.

Leveraging a nationally representative panel of over 16,000 U.S. adults from 2017 to 2024, I provide novel, up-to-date evidence on the prevalence of racial fluidity across key social categories. Over 13 percent of adults change their racial self-classification at least once across eight waves, with racial instability being less common than religious or socioeconomic changes but comparable to instability in party ID. Black, Asian, and, in particular, white categories remain highly stable. Excluding Latinos – who make up over 40 percent of race changes – over 98 percent of white individuals remain white in the next wave. While racial fluidity is most common among young, unmarried, lower SES individuals and those residing in the South and West, random forests reveal that party ID and ideology are by far the strongest predictors of changing one's race, with political independents and moderates being the most likely to do so. Finally, exploiting within-individual variation and using interactive fixed effects, I show that respondents align their race with party ID, education, and religion changes, whereas these processes operate differently for Latinos.

More broadly, this work contributes to our understanding of the social processes underlying race. Racial categories continue to be constrained principally by phenotype and racialization (Irizarry et al. 2022; Monk 2016, 2022; Omi and Winant 1994). By analyzing within-individual changes, however, we can understand the meanings behind racial self-classifications while accounting for unobserved, time-invariant characteristics such as phenotype or skin color. The evidence presented here builds upon work in Latin America that has long nuanced the "money whitens" account. Whereas income does not predict whiter self-classifications, at least in the short term, education sometimes does (Schwartzman 2007), and this result is particularly driven by Latinos. Although there are reasons to suspect that education may foster a sense of racial consciousness (Telles and Paschel 2014), my results are more in line with the history of whiteness as a form of upward racial mobility within early Latino political movements.

Nonetheless, the most important correlate of racial fluidity is, by far, politics. A growing political behavior literature demonstrates the links between partisanship, voting, and racial fluidity (Agadjanian and Lacy 2021; Egan 2020), but the present work is the first to document the highest rates of fluidity among political independents and moderates. Given increasing linkages between partisanship and race over the past several decades (Mason 2018; Westwood and Peterson 2020), these findings indicate that being an independent carries racial meaning such that some independents do not affiliate themselves with certain party-race bundles (cf. Klar and Krupnikov 2016). Additionally, Latinos – who are divided on partisanship and have a unique historical relationship to whiteness – show the strongest relationship between rightward shifts in party ID and white self-classifications.

Receiving less attention in the literature on fluidity, religion emerged as an additional mover connected with racial fluidity. Despite the stability of separate Latino self-classifications, individuals who report a Catholic affiliation are more likely to switch to self-classifying as Latino. Consistent with findings on biracial individuals (Davenport 2016b), changing one's religion to Jewish predicts white self-classifications. As noted earlier, this finding may not represent conversion – though such changes may be particularly likely through marriage – but rather may encompass individuals with Jewish ties or ancestry who choose to sometimes report Jewish affiliation. Contrary to expectations, becoming Mormon is actually related to a lower likelihood of self-classifying as white among Latinos. Historically a white religion, the LDS Church has rapidly diversified in the past few decades. In this context, Latinos who become Mormon may in fact experience more stringent boundaries of whiteness, and, as a result, cease to self-classify as white (Romanello 2021). Lastly, despite the association between Evangelicals and white, racially conservative politics, the null findings here may reflect the increasing diversity of Evangelicals and distinct Evangelical traditions not necessarily tied to whiteness (Putnam et al. 2012).

These findings have important implications for how we understand assimilation and ethnoracial boundaries in the U.S. Despite the increased diversification of the U.S., I uncover similar rates of racial fluidity to those of past work on older panel studies and the overwhelming stability of the white category. Put differently, increased immigration and intermarriages over the past few decades do not appear to have increased rates of racial fluidity. Although this could be due to many reasons – most notably, a distinct survey context and an adult sample compared to prior youth panel studies – findings here suggest another potential explanation. Consistent with the ethnic attrition literature (Duncan and Trejo 2011), individuals who become college-educated – particularly Latinos – may enter into the white category and subsequently remain there. As a result, while immigration and intermarriages continue, many later-generation Latinos and some multiracial individuals may be simultaneously moving and remaining in distinct racial categories like white as they age (Alba 2020). Thus, boundaries of whiteness may be expanding even as rates of instability remain roughly the same and this boundary remains socially consequential (Fox and Guglielmo 2012).

While this work advances our knowledge of racial fluidity, there are a few key limitations with regard to measurement and causal inference. First, the Pew panel is limited in the number of variables re-queried in each wave and the granularity of the data. The region variable, for example, only includes the four broadest Census regions. Future work with more fine-grained measures of place such as ZIP codes could examine how local ethnoracial context affects racial self-classifications. As the present study is unable to make strong causal claims or identify the direction of the relationship, future work with more detailed measures could examine how plausibly exogenous shocks – such as exposure to local Black Lives Matter or 2006 Sensenbrenner bill protests – affect self-classification choices. Finally, the separate race / Latino origin format employed here, though useful for understanding the choices individuals make within constraints, may not accurately reflect racial understandings for many Latinos (Dowling 2015; Hitlin et al. 2007). Future research would do well to examine whether racial fluidity processes differ when a combined question with a Latino option is used.

Nevertheless, the findings are instructive for identity scholars across the social sciences. Even relatively stable categories like whiteness or Latinidad are not fully static. When analyzing surveys at one point in time, researchers should be attentive to inclusion criteria and self-selection into certain categories based on status and other demographics. Among Latinos, for whom self-classifications are highly variable, our understanding of the social-psychological meanings of white, Black, and other distinct identities remains incomplete. Panel studies with more precise measures of identity centrality or strength could assess the stability of identities beyond self-classifications. In doing so, future identity scholarship should continue to center the contextual and social dimensions of race.

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Appendix Figures and Tables

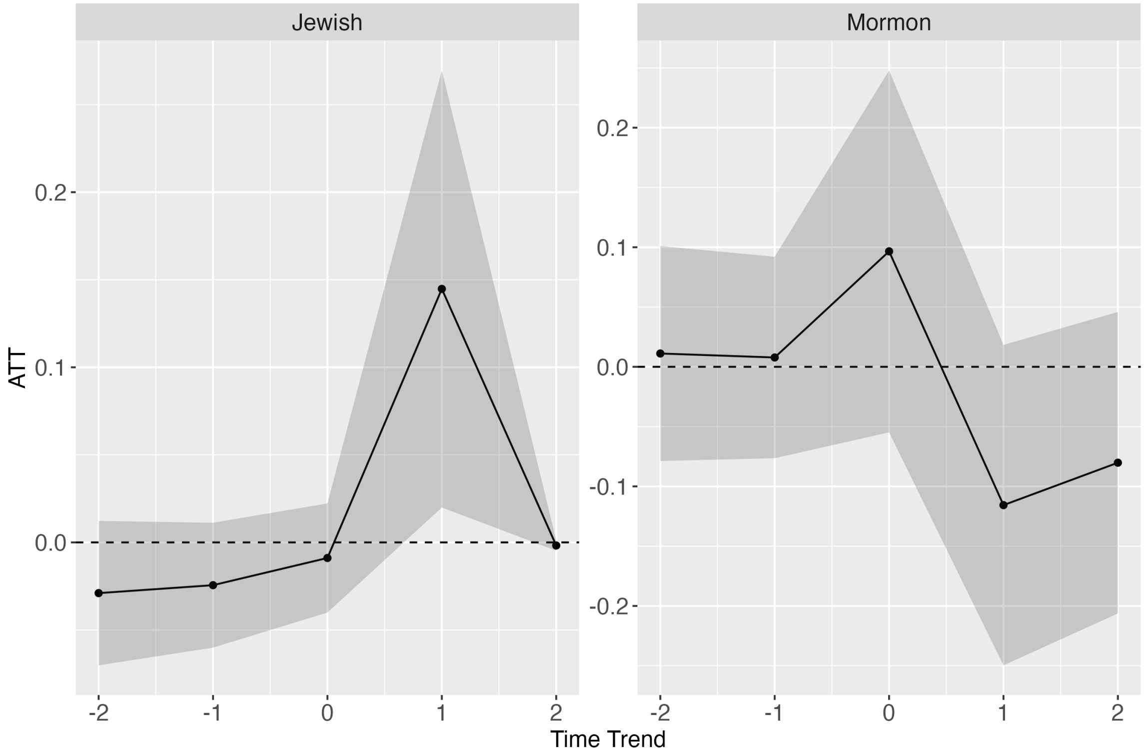

Figure A1: Effect of identifying as Jewish and Mormon on white self-classification. This figure presents time trends for the average treatment effect on the treated (self-classifying as white) using the interactive fixed effects counterfactual (IFEct) estimator. The panels represent binary "treatment" variables for identifying as Jewish (only among non-Latinos) and identifying as Mormon (among Latinos), to replicate TWFE findings. 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals are included.

Variable	Pew American Trends Panel	Benchmark
Race (non-Latino)		
White	63.7	57.8
Black	12.1	12.1
Asian	4.4	5.9
Native American	–	0.7
Mixed race	2.8	6.2
Some other race	0.6	0.3
Don't know / refused	0.9	–
Latino Origin		
Latino	13.9	17.7
Age		
18–29	13.8	20.2
30–49	33.1	25.1
50–64	29.5	25.6
65+	22.5	18.5
Region		
Midwest	21.5	20.8
Northeast	16.2	17.0
South	39.4	38.2
West	21.9	24.0
Sex		
Female	55.5	50.5
Male	43.2	49.5
Other	0.2	–
Citizenship		
Noncitizen	3.7	11.5
Language		
English	96.7	78
Spanish	3.3	13
Other	–	9
Marital Status		
Married	52.1	49
Education		
Less than high school	3.3	10
High school	14.7	27
Some college	31.6	20
College	27.4	23
Graduate degree	23.0	20
Party ID		
Democrat	56.5	51.8
Independent	3.6	9.6
Republican	39.9	38.6
Ideology		
Liberal	30.5	25.8
Moderate	39.1	35.1
Conservative	30.4	39.1

Table A1: Distribution of key demographics compared to benchmarks. This table compares the distribution of key demographics in the current study data to national benchmarks. Benchmarks draw from the 2019-2023 5-year ACS estimates and the 2020 ANES for party ID and ideology.

	Self-Classification	
	Black	Latino
Income	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Education: Some college	0.00	-0.01
	(0.00)	(0.00)
College+	-0.01	-0.01
	(0.01)	(0.01)
Party ID	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Ideology	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Religion: Agnostic/Atheist	0.00	0.01
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Catholic	-0.01	0.01*
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Jewish	-0.02	0.04
	(0.01)	(0.02)
Mormon	-0.02	0.02
	(0.03)	(0.04)
Muslim	0.03	-0.02
	(0.03)	(0.04)
Nothing	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Other	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Married	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Evangelical	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.00)
Region: Midwest	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.01)
South	0.00	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.01)
West	0.00	0.01
	(0.00)	(0.01)
Respondent FE	✓	✓
Wave FE	✓	✓
Observations	72,659	72,659
R^2	0.949	0.953
Within R^2	0.001	0.001

Clustered (Respondent) standard errors in parentheses.
$^*p < 0.05$

Table A2: Two-way fixed effects models predicting Black and Latino self-classification. This table replicates Table 4 in the main text with two distinct binary DVs: Black self-classification and Latino self-classification from the separate Hispanic / Latino origin question.

	White Self-Classification		
	Full Sample	Latino	Non-Latino
Income	0.00	0.02	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Education: Some college	0.00	0.00	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.00)
College+	0.02	0.03	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)
Party ID	0.02*	0.04*	0.01*
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Ideology	0.01	0.01	0.01*
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Latino	-0.07*		
	(0.02)		
Religion: Agnostic/Atheist	0.00	0.02	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Catholic	0.00	0.01	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)
Jewish	0.02	-0.06	0.04*
	(0.02)	(0.05)	(0.02)
Mormon	-0.05*	-0.14*	-0.01
	(0.02)	(0.05)	(0.01)
Muslim	-0.03	-0.16	0.01
	(0.04)	(0.08)	(0.04)
Nothing	0.01	0.01	0.01
	(0.00)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Other	-0.01	-0.07*	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.03)	(0.01)
Married	0.00	-0.01	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.02)	(0.00)
Evangelical	0.00	0.01	0.00
	(0.00)	(0.01)	(0.00)
Region: Midwest	0.00	0.02	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.09)	(0.01)
South	0.01	0.04	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.08)	(0.01)
West	0.01	0.07	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.07)	(0.01)
Respondent FE	✓	✓	✓
Wave FE	✓	✓	✓
Observations	71,423	10,171	61,252
R^2	0.910	0.772	0.943
Within R^2	0.003	0.004	0.001

Clustered (Respondent) standard errors in parentheses.
$^*p < 0.05$

Table A3: Two-way fixed effects models predicting white self-classification, dropping likely measurement error. This table replicates Table 4 in the main text but drops individuals with likely misreports. Individuals who report more than one citizenship change or more than one age change (which is impossible due to the age categories used in the panel) are dropped.